Methodological approaches to Open Educational Resources (OERs) for cultural heritage professionals

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In 2021, following the evaluation of the previous recommendation on the digitisation and online accessibility of cultural material and digital preservation (EU 2011), the European Commission issued updated guidance on establishing a common European data space for cultural heritage. This recommendation pointed out the urgent need to accelerate the digitisation process of cultural heritage in order to enable Member States to contribute to the goals of the Digital Decade actively. At the same time, the document also highlighted a significant obstacle to this acceleration: the digital skills gap affecting many professionals in the cultural heritage sector.

Despite various initiatives, the digital divide within cultural heritage institutions has been a recurring theme in global reports. Studies often focus on aggregated data from multiple countries or spotlight isolated success stories (UNESCO 2015, 2020: 6, 15; 2021; Museum Booster 2021). However, there is a notable lack of detailed evidence addressing the specific challenges faced by small Mediterranean islands. These regions, often resource-constrained and geographically isolated, represent a unique set of challenges and opportunities in the digital transformation of cultural heritage.

In this short paper, I will address this gap by focusing on the digital divide within the cultural heritage sector in Cyprus and the smaller islands of Italy, Croatia, and Greece. I propose a methodological framework for developing Open Educational Resources (OERs) tailored to cultural heritage professionals. The aim is to provide support to reduce the digital divide by equipping professionals with the skills and knowledge needed to engage meaningfully in digital practices.

The methodology points to combining digital humanities and social science approaches to create practical, accessible, and user-focused OERs. These resources are designed specifically for museums and cultural heritage management (CHM) staff, addressing their unique digital gaps.

Unlike conventional user manuals or traditional academic outputs, this approach prioritizes practical, step-by-step guidance tailored to the effective and specific needs of cultural heritage professionals. By focusing on actionable insights, the OERs empower users to develop digital content and strategies that meet the demands of the modern cultural heritage landscape.

This paper constitutes a preliminary presentation of an ongoing three-year research project named “Digital Storytelling in Cultural Heritage Institutions of Small Mediterranean Islands”, cofunded by the YUFE4 Postdocs-Marie Sklodowska-Curie program.

In the first section of the paper, I will assess the current state of digitisation reached by the cultural heritage institutions in the selected regions. The analysis focuses on three primary indicators: the presence of a website, activity on social media, and the online availability of any digital assets. These three indicators were chosen as representative benchmarks for an institution’s level of engagement with digital technologies. To ensure an objective evaluation, each parameter is assessed on a three-level scale: low, medium, and high.

The study includes 228 islands, of which 98 are in Greece, 84 in Italy, and 41 in Croatia, alongside Cyprus. A total of 347 cultural heritage institutions were analysed. Preliminary data indicate that the overall level of digitisation across all three parameters is generally low (fig. 1). This suggests a significant need for targeted interventions to enhance digital engagement within these institutions.

This quantitative analysis will be implemented with data collected through a questionnaire distributed to cultural heritage professionals in the target regions. The questionnaire, comprising 24 questions, explores a range of topics, including demographic information, the digitisation status of their respective institutions, and perceptions of current digital and technological practices within the sector. Distributed both online and onsite, the questionnaire aims to provide a deeper understanding of the digital divide among professionals and further refine the assessment of institutional digitisation levels.

The questionnaire analysis constitutes the core of the second section of the paper where I will highlight digital gaps and needs of cultural heritage professionals. This needs analysis represents a pivotal step in understanding the challenges faced by this group. In the next phase of the project, the analysis will be enriched with qualitative data gathered through interviews with a smaller subset of cultural heritage professionals. By cross-re-

ferencing the results of the questionnaire and the interviews, I will get data that will be used to develop personas that represent the target audience. These personas will serve as a foundation for designing OERs that address the specific requirements of cultural heritage professionals in these regions.

The final section of the paper emphasizes the transformative potential of OERs in addressing these challenges. OERs play a crucial role in the upskilling and reskilling of cultural heritage professionals, equipping them with the tools and knowledge needed to navigate an increasingly digital world. Moreover, the need for these kinds of support is even more urgent due to the lack of availability of these materials. A preliminary benchmark analysis, indeed, shows that the majority of educational material for digital humanities is mainly intended for students while the support for the use of digital tools is constituted by manuals with a technical cutting.

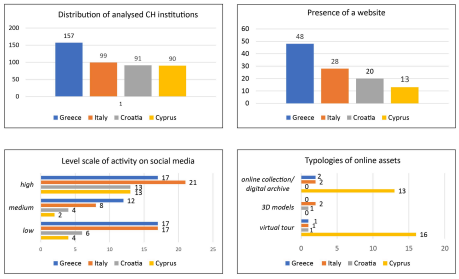

Fig. 1 – Charts showing information about the cultural heritage institutions analysed in the project

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